IELTS Preparation Foundations

The four sections, band scores and the foundations of preparation — Free preview

IELTS is an international test of English language skills. Many people who want to study, work or live in an English-speaking country need its result. Understanding the test structure clearly is the first step of preparation.

IELTS has four sections: Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking. The total time is about 2 hours 45 minutes. Listening is about 30 minutes (40 questions), Reading 60 minutes (40 questions), Writing 60 minutes (2 tasks), Speaking 11 to 14 minutes (3 parts).

What is it?

There are two versions of IELTS: Academic and General Training. Listening and Speaking are the same in both. Reading and Writing differ — Academic is for study and professional work, General Training is for work, training or migration. Check with the institution or authority you are applying to which version you need.

There is no pass or fail in IELTS. Each section is scored on a band scale from 0 to 9, and the overall band score is the average of the four sections, rounded to the nearest half band. This guide promises no particular score; your target band is set by the institution you apply to. No test fee is given in this guide — check the official IELTS site for the current fee.

How to start — a glimpse

1. First decide whether you need Academic or General Training — check the requirements of the institution you are applying to.
2. Write down the time and number of questions for each of the four sections once, so you do not lose track of time on test day.

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